Unusual 2NT

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The Unusual 2NT overcall is used after the opponents open the bidding. A 2NT overcall is artificial, showing **the two lowest unbid suits** (at least 5-5 shape). There is no point minimum, although obvious factors like vulnerability should be considered. See also the Michaels cuebid, a complementary convention for showing 5-5 hands, and Unusual vs. Unusual, a defense to the Unusual 2NT.

Unusual 2NT Overcalls

Overcall	Meaning
A 2NT overcall of 1♣	5+ hearts and 5+ diamonds.
A 2NT overcall of 1♦	5+ hearts and 5+ clubs.
A 2NT overcall of 1♥	5+ diamonds and 5+ clubs.
A 2NT overcall of 1♠	5+ diamonds and 5+ clubs.

The Unusual 2NT is possible if one or both opponents have bid:

South
♠ 76
♥ 9
♦ AJT84
♣ KJ982

West	North	East	South
1♥	Pass	1♠	2NT (1)

(1) 5+ clubs and 5+ diamonds. Note that this is an overlap with the Michaels cue bid here - a 2♥ overcall would also show 5+ clubs and 5+ diamonds. Also, note that the overcaller could alternatively make a takeout double, which would imply lesser shape and at least ~12 HCP.

South
♠ 7
♥ A9832
♦ AJT842
♣ J

West	North	East	South
1♣	Pass	1NT	2NT (1)

(1) 5+ hearts and 5+ diamonds.

Partner's Responses

- Partner usually bids the suit that he has the most tolerance for. With equal length in both suits, especially with two doubletons, he bids the cheapest suit.

  General Note: When responding to the Unusual 2NT with equal length in both advertised suits, bid the cheapest suit first, e.g. 3♣ with ♣xx ♦Kx. You can run to diamonds if the opponents double.

- If partner has a weak hand with at least 4-card support, he can consider making a preemptive jump bid:

West	North	East	South
1♥	2NT	Pass	4♣

  4♣ is preemptive and non-forcing, promising at least 4 clubs.

- With a good hand, partner can cue bid the opponents' suit. This typically shows support for at least one of partner's suits, and interest in game or slam. A cue bid is forcing for one round and asks the 2NT bidder to bid his cheapest suit at the cheapest level with a weak hand (around 0-10 points), or to make any other bid with a "fair" hand (around 10+ points).

- If by chance partner bids the "fourth suit", i.e. the suit not bid by the opponents or shown by partner, that bid is natural and nonforcing, showing a very good suit (usually 6+ cards), a decent hand, and no support for either of the 2NT bidder's suits.

Rebids by the 2NT Bidder

Raises are natural and non-forcing. All other bids show a very good hand (in terms of points and/or shape) but, with the exception of a cue bid, are non-forcing.

Other Considerations

- The Unusual Notrump is a useful convention because:
  - it immediately shows partner a specific two-suited hand that would otherwise take two bids to illustrate.
  - it preempts the opponents.
  - it only gives up a natural 20-21 HCP 2NT overcall, which virtually never occurs and can still be shown with a takeout double and 2NT rebid anyway.
- A 2NT overcall of 1NT needs to be defined by partnership agreement. In some conventional 1NT defenses like Cappelletti, a 2NT overcall does show the 2 lowest suits (clubs and diamonds). In other conventions like DONT, however, a different overcall such as 2♣ is used to show clubs and diamonds.
- A 2NT overcall of artificial opening bids such as a Precision 1♣ also needs to be defined by partnership agreement.
- The Unusual 2NT works well in conjunction with the Michaels cue bid, which is another convention for two-suited overcalls.
- There is also a conventional defense against the Unusual 2NT called Unusual vs. Unusual.

Additional Examples

The Unusual 2NT is also in effect if both opponents have bid up to 2♠:

South
♠ 6
♥ KT9832

West	North	East	South
1♣	Pass	2♣	2NT (1)

♦ QJT93
♣ 2

(1) 5+ hearts and 5+ diamonds.

South
♠ AQJ872
♥ 32
♦ —
♣ KQJT9

West	North	East	South
1♥	Pass	2♦	2NT (1)

(1) 5+ clubs and 5+ spades. Be careful after an opposing 2-over-1 sequence. The opponents have announced that they have the majority of points, so an Unusual 2NT overcall typically promises extra length or strength, especially at equal or unfavorable vulnerability.

South
♠ J83
♥ —
♦ AJT93
♣ KQJT9

West	North	East	South
Pass	Pass	2♥ (1)	2NT (2)

1. Strong
2. Over a strong two-bid by the opponents, a 2NT overcall is Unusual. Here, 2NT shows 5+ clubs and 5+ diamonds.

South
♠ Q63
♥ AT987
♦ AJT93
♣ —

West	East	East	South
Pass	Pass	2♣ (1)	2NT (2)

1. In the Precision bidding system, an opening 2♣ bid shows 6+ clubs and 11-15 HCP. It therefore fits the definition of "a natural, constructive two-bid"
2. Therefore, a 2NT overcall is the Unusual 2NT, showing 5+ diamonds and 5+ hearts.

South
♠ AQ63
♥ KJ3
♦ K32
♣ AT9

West	North	East	South
Pass	Pass	2♥ (1)	2NT (2)

1. Weak
2. This is *not* the Unusual 2NT, because 2♥ is preemptive, not constructive. 2NT shows a balanced, natural ~16-19 HCP.